

2026 EDITION · STRATEGIC BUYER'S GUIDE

The **Workday** Buyer's Guide

A practical, research-enhanced guide for deciding whether Workday is the right HCM and finance platform, and whether your organization is ready to implement it without creating governance, reporting, data, adoption, or cost problems.

PREPARED BY

Align HCM

EDITION

2026

BUILT FOR

CHRO · CFO · HRIS

For CHROs, CFOs, HRIS leaders, finance leaders, and transformation teams. Use this as the companion to Align HCM's live [Strategic Buyer's Guide to Workday](#): the web article gives the high-level fit framework, and this document turns that same position into a working evaluation, readiness, governance, TCO, and post-go-live planning guide.

Contents

Fourteen chapters from fit framework to a buyer workbook you can fill in.

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THE CORE IDEA

Workday is strongest when the buyer needs one governed operating model for people, finance, planning, reporting, and change. It gets weakest when the buyer treats it like a cleaner HR database.

01 Executive Summary

Workday should feel less like a software purchase and more like an operating model decision.

Workday can be a powerful platform for organizations that need more than HR administration. The real value shows up when HR, Finance, IT, Payroll, Operations, and executives need one trusted model for workforce data, organizational structure, talent movement, planning, reporting, and business change.

The software demo usually looks clean. The hard part comes later, when the organization has to define how jobs, positions, supervisory organizations, cost centers, security roles, payroll providers, reports, integrations, approvals, and business processes should work together.

11,500+

customers globally, per Workday

75M+

users under contract

7,000+

core HCM & Financial Management customers

That scale matters, but scale doesn't remove buyer responsibility. A platform this broad rewards organizations that make decisions clearly, clean data early, fund change management properly, and keep ownership active after go-live.

The best Workday buyers don't ask, "Can Workday do this?"

They ask:

- Are we complex enough for Workday to create meaningful value?
- Are we prepared to redesign the processes our current systems have been hiding?
- Can HR and Finance agree on workforce definitions before build starts?
- Do we have the internal owners needed to make fast, cross-functional decisions?
- Can we support Workday after implementation without letting the platform drift?
- Are we buying AI and analytics capability we can realistically activate?

If the operating model is ready, Workday can help simplify complexity. If the operating model is not ready, Workday can expose every decision the business has avoided.

BUYER TAKEAWAY

Workday is a strong fit when the business needs enterprise-level HR and finance alignment, mature governance, clean reporting, and long-term platform ownership. The risk rises when the buyer wants transformation but lacks the internal structure to support it.

02 The Workday Decision Buyers Are Really Making

Workday is not just competing against ADP, Dayforce, UKG, or another HCM platform. For many buyers, Workday is competing against the current operating reality:

- HR has one headcount number and Finance has another.
- Reorganizations take weeks of spreadsheet work.
- Managers don't trust the reporting library.
- Employees still open tickets for tasks the system was supposed to simplify.
- IT owns integrations nobody in the business can explain.
- Payroll depends on regional providers, custom feeds, and manual validation.
- AI capabilities exist in the tenant but the business has no adoption plan.
- The organization is still making workforce decisions from stale exports.

Workday's official HCM positioning emphasizes one suite of HR, payroll, talent, workforce planning, analytics, workforce management, employee experience, and global capabilities designed to work together. The buyer question is whether your organization can make that promise operational.

The Workday decision usually has four layers

1. Platform fit

Workday makes the most sense when the organization has enough complexity to justify a unified enterprise platform: matrix structures, multi-entity operations, workforce planning needs, frequent reorgs, global or regional payroll coordination, deep reporting requirements, and strong HR-Finance dependency.

2. Transformation readiness

Workday doesn't create clean ownership by itself. Leaders need to decide who owns job architecture, position management, security, integrations, reporting, change management, and release management before implementation exposes the gaps.

3. Data and reporting discipline

Workday can centralize data, but it won't magically reconcile conflicting definitions. If HR, Finance, Operations, and IT don't agree on headcount, cost center, worker type, position, job, location, and supervisory organization logic, the reporting pain will move into the new platform.

4. Long-term ownership

Workday keeps changing. New releases, AI capabilities, reporting tools, integration options, and workflow improvements create ongoing work. Buyers need a post-go-live model that keeps Workday healthy after the launch team leaves.

BUYER TAKEAWAY

The right question is not whether Workday is powerful. The right question is whether your company has enough complexity, leadership alignment, and operating discipline to turn that power into value.

03 The Pain Points Workday Should Solve

Workday pain is not the same as Dayforce pain or ADP pain.

- **ADP buyers** usually feel payroll, compliance, service, product-fit, and implementation risk.
- **Dayforce buyers** usually feel time, scheduling, payroll calculation, manager ownership, and real-time workforce complexity.
- **Workday buyers** usually feel enterprise transformation pain. The organization has outgrown disconnected HR and finance processes.

This guide keeps the same buyer lens as Align HCM's live Workday page: Workday makes sense when complexity is the business problem, but the platform only pays off when the buyer can govern data, processes, integrations, reporting, change, and long-term ownership.

Pain Point One — HR and Finance don't trust the same numbers

When HR and Finance define headcount differently, every workforce conversation slows down. Finance may care about cost center and budget ownership. HR may care about supervisory organization and employee lifecycle. Operations may care about location, role, schedule, and capacity. Align's reporting guidance calls out the common pattern: teams build reports reactively, create duplicate logic, and eventually stop trusting the reports they just paid for.

BUYER QUESTION

Which workforce metrics need one enterprise definition before go-live?

Pain Point Two — the org model is more complex than the current system can handle

Matrix reporting, frequent reorgs, multiple entities, cost center changes, shared services, acquisitions, and hybrid work arrangements all create pressure on legacy HRIS setups. Workday's value grows when the platform can model the real organization instead of forcing teams into shadow spreadsheets.

BUYER QUESTION

How often do org, job, cost center, or manager changes require manual cleanup today?

Pain Point Three — data migration exposes years of shortcuts

Workday implementation forces the business to move employee, job, position, compensation, payroll, benefits, organization, security, and historical data into a new model. That work often reveals inconsistent

job codes, inactive positions, stale manager assignments, mismatched cost centers, missing locations, duplicate records, and policy exceptions nobody documented. Research on ERP implementation success factors has long shown that organizational fit, change readiness, process redesign, and data discipline affect implementation outcomes. Treat data work as a core project lane, not a cleanup task.

BUYER QUESTION

What data do we need to clean before configuration begins?

Pain Point Four — integrations are owned technically, not operationally

Workday often needs to connect with payroll providers, benefits carriers, identity systems, recruiting tools, learning systems, ERP or finance tools, data warehouses, and downstream reporting environments. A technical feed can still fail the business if nobody owns the business rule behind it.

BUYER QUESTION

For each integration, who owns the business outcome after go-live?

Pain Point Five — change management is treated as communications

Workday changes how people request, approve, report, plan, and manage work. Training someone to click through a workflow is not enough. Managers need to understand what their actions do to pay, approvals, reporting, compliance, employee experience, and downstream data.

Prosci reports that projects with excellent change management are up to **7X** more likely to achieve change success. For Workday, the people side is not soft. It is a direct driver of adoption, support volume, and return on investment.

BUYER QUESTION

Which groups need behavior change, not just system training?

Pain Point Six — AI is bought faster than it is adopted

Workday reported 1.7 billion AI actions across its platform in fiscal 2026, and Workday's customer facts page says over 75% of core Workday customers use Workday AI. The opportunity is real, but buyers still need to ask whether their own tenant, data, roles, governance, and training are ready. The problem is not only whether AI exists. The problem is whether the organization knows what it owns, where AI could reduce manual work, and how adoption will be measured.

BUYER QUESTION

Which manual HR, finance, recruiting, manager, or employee workflows are painful enough to justify AI activation?

04 When Workday Is the Right Fit

Workday is usually strongest when the organization has enterprise complexity and leadership wants HR and Finance to work from one operating model.

Strong-fit signals

- 1,500+ employees, or structural complexity that behaves like a larger enterprise.
- Matrix management, frequent reorganizations, shared services, or multi-entity operations.
- HR and Finance need aligned headcount, workforce cost, and planning logic.
- Talent, skills, succession, or learning needs are strategically important.
- Leaders need better workforce analytics, not just cleaner employee records.
- The organization wants a long-term HCM and finance platform, not a short-term payroll fix.
- The buyer has executive sponsorship, internal capacity, and budget for implementation, change management, integrations, training, and post-go-live support.

Workday can also fit organizations preparing for growth, acquisition, restructuring, or global expansion. The more the business depends on consistent workforce definitions and adaptable organization models, the stronger the Workday case becomes.

Nucleus Research's Enterprise HCM Technology Value Matrix 2025 describes large enterprises as pursuing comprehensive, integrated HR solutions to unify data, processes, and people with fewer vendors. Buyers are not just shopping for HR transactions. They are trying to reduce fragmentation.

Common Workday fit profiles

The HR & Finance transformation buyer

Wants shared planning, cleaner workforce cost visibility, and fewer reconciliation fights between HR and Finance.

The complex enterprise buyer

Has matrix structures, frequent org changes, multiple entities, and reporting needs the current system can't support cleanly.

The talent strategy buyer

Needs talent, learning, succession, skills, internal mobility, and workforce planning to connect in one architecture.

The post-acquisition buyer

Is consolidating systems after growth, acquisition, or restructuring and needs cleaner governance across job, position, organization, payroll, and finance data.

BUYER TAKEAWAY

Workday makes sense when complexity is the business problem. It isn't the best choice only because the brand is known or the demo looks modern.

05 When Workday May Be Too Much Platform

A strong buyer's guide should be honest about the wrong fit. Workday may be more platform than the organization needs when:

- HR requirements are straightforward.
- The workforce is mostly salaried, stable, and operationally simple.
- The company doesn't need deep HR-Finance planning integration.
- Leadership wants a fast payroll replacement, not a business transformation.
- The team lacks internal project ownership across HR, Finance, IT, Payroll, and Operations.
- Data cleanup would be deferred until after contract signature.
- The budget covers licensing but not implementation, integrations, training, reporting strategy, change management, release management, or post-go-live support.
- The organization wants advanced AI and analytics but can't define which manual workflows need improvement.

Workday can underperform when buyers overbuy the platform and underfund the operating model. The result is familiar: go-live happens, but reporting is messy, managers avoid workflows, HR keeps workarounds, Finance still exports data, and the internal team is stuck asking why the platform did not transform the business.

Don't buy Workday yet if:

- HR and Finance can't agree on core workforce definitions.
- No one owns data quality.
- No one owns reporting governance.
- No one owns integrations after go-live.
- The project sponsor can't resolve cross-functional decisions quickly.
- Managers are not part of adoption planning.
- The business case depends on AI capability without an activation plan.

BUYER TAKEAWAY

Workday isn't overkill because it's large. It becomes overkill when the buyer isn't ready to govern it.

06 Implementation Readiness

Workday implementations succeed or struggle before configuration begins.

The Align Workday implementation page names the right problem: the decisions made before a single screen is configured determine whether the rollout moves smoothly or becomes costly and drawn out. The technology matters, but leadership gaps, unclear process ownership, weak change management, and poor data quality are usually the real failure points.

Gate One — Executive sponsorship

The sponsor needs authority across HR, Finance, IT, Payroll, and Operations. Workday decisions cross functions constantly. When executive sponsorship is vague, the project waits for decisions and scope starts to drift.

Gate Two — Internal project ownership

An implementation partner can guide the work. The buyer still owns the business decisions. Someone inside the organization needs the authority, availability, and credibility to answer process, data, and ownership questions quickly.

Gate Three — Process redesign

Workday should not be used to recreate every workaround from the old environment. Buyers need to decide which processes should stay, which should change, and which should be retired.

Gate Four — Data audit

Before build starts, the buyer should audit employee data, job architecture, position data, cost centers, pay groups, benefits, security roles, locations, supervisory organizations, historical data, payroll provider data, and reporting dependencies.

Gate Five — Integration inventory

Every inbound and outbound feed needs a named business owner, technical owner, testing owner, and post-go-live support owner.

Gate Six — Training and adoption plan

Training should be role-based. HR administrators, payroll teams, finance users, managers, employees, IT, and executives need different learning paths.

Gate Seven — Hypercare and SmartCare planning

The first 90 days after go-live should not be improvised. Buyers need issue triage, defect management, reporting review, payroll and finance validation, adoption tracking, and a path into ongoing optimization.

BUYER TAKEAWAY

Readiness isn't paperwork. It is the difference between a Workday launch and a Workday operating model.

07 Data, Integrations & Reporting Governance

Most Workday pain after go-live comes from governance decisions that were missed before go-live.

| Data governance

The core question is simple: who has authority over each data domain?

- Worker data.
- Job and position data.
- Supervisory organization.
- Cost center and financial dimensions.
- Compensation and pay group logic.
- Benefits and eligibility.
- Security roles.
- Location and legal entity.
- Reporting definitions.
- Integration ownership.

Without ownership, the platform fills with exceptions. Reports break. Managers lose trust. HRIS becomes a ticket queue. Finance returns to spreadsheets.

| Integration governance

Workday integrations are not just technical connections. Each integration represents a business dependency. Common Workday integration areas include payroll providers, benefits carriers, identity and SSO, recruiting and onboarding, learning systems, time and attendance tools where specialized requirements exist, finance or ERP systems, data warehouses and BI tools, background checks and verification services, and third-party compliance tools.

Each integration should have: a business purpose, a source of truth, a field owner, an error-handling process, a testing plan, a support owner, and a change-control plan.

| Reporting governance

Align's Workday reporting article gets the pain right. Reporting usually breaks because teams build reactively. A request comes in, someone copies a report, logic changes slightly, and eventually the library becomes too messy to trust. The fix is not more reports. The fix is a reporting philosophy.

A Workday reporting strategy should define:

- Which executive questions need standard dashboards.

- Which metrics need one approved definition.
- Which reports should be delivered, custom, discovery board, or analytics layer.
- Who owns report naming, documentation, access, and retirement.
- How headcount, turnover, vacancy, position, cost center, and worker population logic will be governed.
- How report changes will be handled after reorgs, releases, and process updates.

BUYER TAKEAWAY

Workday should reduce reporting friction. Without governance, it can become a better-looking way to produce the same confusion.

08 AI, Illuminate & Adoption Readiness

Workday's AI story is becoming more important to the business case. Workday says its platform supports human-AI collaboration, and its fiscal 2026 results reported 1.7 billion AI actions across the platform. Workday's customer facts page also says over 75% of core Workday customers use Workday AI.

1.7B

AI actions across the platform in fiscal 2026

75%+

of core Workday customers use Workday AI

7X

more likely to succeed with excellent change management (Prosci)

The risk is buying the AI story without an adoption plan.

AI value depends on real use cases

- Reducing repetitive HR questions.
- Improving employee self-service.
- Supporting recruiters with high-volume tasks.
- Helping managers act on workforce insights.
- Improving expense, finance, or planning workflows.
- Surfacing skills and talent opportunities.
- Reducing manual report interpretation.

AI also depends on readiness

- Clean data.
- Clear security roles.
- Documented business processes.
- Manager and employee trust.
- Human review where decisions carry risk.
- Governance around how AI is used in HR and finance workflows.
- Measurement beyond "we turned it on."

Align's AI Activation Assessment angle fits the Workday buyer pain well. Many organizations already own more capability than they use. The opportunity is not to chase AI for its own sake. It is to identify the manual work slowing down HR, Finance, managers, recruiters, and employees, then match Workday capability to practical adoption plans.

BUYER TAKEAWAY

Workday AI can strengthen the business case, but only when the buyer connects it to real workflows, clean data, governance, and adoption.

09 Total Cost of Ownership

Workday cost should be evaluated over years, not months.

Gartner Digital Markets' 2025 HR Software Trends Survey reported that **70%** of HR leaders expect HR software costs to rise and **60%** plan to boost investment, based on 3,256 respondents across 11 countries. The market isn't moving toward less HR technology spend. It is moving toward more disciplined spend.

A practical Workday TCO model should include

- Subscription fees by module and employee population.
- Implementation partner services.
- Internal project team time.
- Data conversion and cleanup.
- Integration design, build, testing, and maintenance.
- Reporting architecture and report cleanup.
- Security design and testing.
- Change management and communications.
- Role-based training.
- Payroll or third-party provider coordination.
- Hypercare after go-live.
- Release testing and adoption.
- Ongoing admin, optimization, and SmartCare support.
- Future module expansion.
- AI activation and adoption work.

The mistake is treating implementation as the whole cost. Workday is a living platform. Releases, AI capabilities, reporting needs, reorganizations, acquisitions, process changes, and workforce shifts all create ongoing work.

Cost questions buyers should answer early

- What is included in year one? What becomes a year-two add-on?
- Which integrations are custom?
- How much internal capacity will be needed during implementation?
- Who supports Workday after go-live?
- What reporting work is included? What change management work is included? What release management work is included?

- What does optimization look like after the first 90 days?

BUYER TAKEAWAY

The cheapest Workday proposal is not always the lowest-risk Workday decision. Underfunded implementation creates expensive cleanup.

10 Questions Buyers Should Ask

Ask Workday

- Which modules are included in the proposal, and which capabilities require additional licensing?
- Which parts of our use case fit standard Workday functionality, and which require configuration, partner work, or future phases?
- How does pricing scale with headcount, countries, entities, modules, and AI capabilities?
- Which payroll geographies are native, managed, partner-supported, or third-party?
- Which integrations are prebuilt, partner-built, or custom?
- What standard support is included, and what requires premium support?
- How should we plan for release testing and adoption?
- Which AI capabilities are available now in our proposed scope?
- What customer references match our size, industry, and complexity?

Ask the implementation partner

- How many Workday implementations have you supported for organizations like ours?
- Who will be on the delivery team, and what Workday experience do they have?
- How do you handle client-side decision-making when HR, Finance, IT, and Operations disagree?
- How do you document job, position, organization, security, and reporting decisions?
- What is your data conversion method?
- How do you test integrations with business owners, not only technical owners?
- What usually breaks first after go-live?
- How do you transition from implementation to SmartCare, optimization, or long-term support?

Ask internally

- What pain are we trying to remove?
- Which current processes are worth keeping? Which are only workarounds?
- Who owns each core data domain?
- Which reports do executives actually need?
- How will we support managers after training?

- How will we measure adoption?
- What happens if HR and Finance disagree on a definition?
- Who owns Workday after the project team leaves?

BUYER TAKEAWAY

Good questions protect the buyer from buying a platform without buying the operating model needed to run it.

11 Workday Decision Scorecard

Score each area from 1 to 5 by shading the boxes.

PLATFORM FIT

Organization has enough complexity to justify Workday.	00000
HR and Finance need shared workforce planning and reporting logic.	00000
Talent, skills, succession, or learning needs are strategically important.	00000
Current system fragmentation creates measurable risk or waste.	00000
Workday Financial Management or planning integration is part of the strategic case.	00000

IMPLEMENTATION READINESS

Executive sponsor is named and active.	00000
Internal project owner has decision authority.	00000
HR, Finance, IT, Payroll, and Operations are aligned on project governance.	00000
Process redesign is funded.	00000
Data audit can start before configuration.	00000
Integration inventory is complete.	00000
Change management is budgeted beyond basic training.	00000

POST-GO-LIVE MODEL

SmartCare, optimization, or managed support is planned.	00000
Reporting governance is owned.	00000
Release management is owned.	00000
AI activation has use cases and measurement.	00000

Scoring guide

55 to 80: strong fit. Proceed with disciplined implementation planning.

40 to 54: conditional fit. Resolve governance, data, TCO, or adoption gaps before contract signature.

Below 40: pause. Revisit timing, platform scope, partner model, or internal readiness.

12 How Align HCM Helps

Align HCM helps buyers make HCM platform decisions with the operating reality in view.

Assessment

We pressure-test Workday fit against company size, complexity, HR and Finance needs, implementation readiness, reporting needs, data quality, integration scope, and long-term ownership.

Implementation

We support implementation planning, project execution, configuration decisions, testing, go-live readiness, and stabilization.

Client-side services

We help the internal team make decisions, keep the project moving, translate business needs into platform requirements, and protect the buyer's interests throughout the implementation.

Data conversion

We help map, clean, validate, and load the data Workday needs to operate properly.

System integration

We help plan and support integrations across payroll, benefits, identity, recruiting, learning, finance, reporting, and other systems that shape the operating model.

Training & Align Academy

We build role-based training that helps HR, Finance, Payroll, managers, employees, and administrators use the system correctly.

Optimization

We help clean up reports, refine processes, improve adoption, activate unused capabilities, and make Workday more valuable after go-live.

SmartCare

We support the system after launch through stabilization, ongoing support, optimization, and transformation work.

FREE ASSESSMENT — PRESSURE-TEST YOUR WORKDAY DECISION BEFORE YOU COMMIT

Align HCM offers a complimentary Workday readiness or optimization assessment for organizations weighing the platform or already running it. What you receive:

- Independent fit recommendation.

- Implementation readiness scoring.
- Data, integration, reporting, and governance risk review.
- Recommended next-90-day plan.

Get in touch with Align HCM and mention the Workday Buyer's Guide when scheduling.

13 Source Notes

Workday HCM overview

Workday positions HCM as an integrated HR suite spanning core HCM, payroll, workforce planning, analytics, talent, workforce management, employee experience, and related capabilities.

Workday customer facts

More than 11,500 customers globally, more than 75 million users under contract, more than 90% of customer deployments completed on time in FY26, and over 75% of core Workday customers using Workday AI.

Workday fiscal 2026 results

More than 11,500 customers globally, more than 7,000 core Workday Financial Management and Workday HCM customers, and 1.7 billion AI actions across its platform in fiscal 2026.

Gartner Digital Markets 2025 HR Software Trends

70% of HR leaders expect HR software costs to rise and 60% plan to boost investment, based on 3,256 respondents across 11 countries.

Nucleus Research Enterprise HCM Technology Value Matrix 2025

Describes enterprise HCM buyers as seeking comprehensive, integrated HR solutions that unify data, processes, and people with fewer vendors.

Prosci change management success research

Projects with excellent change management are up to 7X more likely to achieve change success.

ERP implementation research

Peer-reviewed research on ERP implementation highlights organizational fit, change management, process redesign, and readiness as central success factors.

Align HCM Workday resources

Align's Workday partner page, implementation guidance, reporting guidance, AI gap article, and service pages were used to align the pain points with Align's actual Workday positioning.

Peer-reviewed academic research sources

These journal studies support the guide's implementation readiness, adoption, data quality, and ongoing governance claims.

Hong & Kim — Information & Management

ERP implementation success depends on organizational fit and implementation contingencies.

Umble, Haft & Umble — European Journal of Operational Research

ERP implementations require disciplined procedures, project management, change management, and critical success factors.

DeLone & McLean — Journal of Management Information Systems

Information quality, system quality, service quality, use, user satisfaction, and net benefits shape information system success.

Venkatesh et al. — MIS Quarterly

Technology acceptance depends on performance expectancy, effort expectancy, social influence, and facilitating conditions.

14 Buyer Workbook

Print these worksheets or fill them in digitally. They turn the guide into your own decision record.

Worksheet One — Define the Pain

The Workday problem we are trying to solve is:

.....

The current workaround is:

.....

The business cost of keeping the workaround is:

.....

The result we want twelve months after go-live is:

.....

Worksheet Two — Map Workday Fit

Employee count:

.....

Payroll providers:

.....

Countries:

.....

Benefits carriers:

.....

States or provinces:

.....

Critical integrations:

.....

Legal entities:

.....

Current reporting pain:

.....

Cost centers:

.....

Likely Workday scope:

.....

Supervisory organizations:

Worksheet Three — Data Readiness (score 1–5; anything below 3 needs cleanup before build)

Worker data	00000
Job architecture	00000
Position data	00000
Supervisory organization	00000
Cost center and finance dimensions	00000
Location and legal entity	00000
Compensation and pay group logic	00000
Benefits eligibility	00000
Security roles	00000
Historical data	00000
Reporting definitions	00000

Worksheet Four — Reporting Governance

Define the official owner, source logic, approved definition, report type, security model, and review cadence for each metric.

Headcount	Worker type
Turnover	Cost center
Open positions	Location
Vacancy	Manager hierarchy
Labor cost	

Worksheet Five — AI Activation Readiness

Which Workday AI capabilities do we already own?

.....

Which manual HR or Finance workflows create the most pain?

.....

Which user groups would need training and trust-building?

.....

What metric would prove AI adoption is working?

.....

Worksheet Six — First 90 Days

0–30 days:

Stabilize core workflows, payroll and finance handoffs, integrations, defects, access issues, and user support.

.....

31–60 days:

Normalize reporting, manager self-service, employee workflows, security requests, and support ownership.

.....

61–90 days:

Optimize configuration, clean reports, improve adoption, activate practical capabilities, and transition to SmartCare or ongoing support.

.....

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